

but strangely enough, it retains the font of the header but not of the remaining text. QuarkXPress was quite bad in this regard—it doesn't import text if it is saved in the default MS Word format. You can import text only in RTF format, but all the formatting gets lost. Like PageMaker, Adobe Frame Maker, InDesign and Microsoft Publisher maintain the text formatting.

PageMaker and InDesign do an excellent job of importing data as it is from MS Excel. Quark again disappoints here. Frame Maker does import the Excel sheet but only if it is saved in version 5.0. However, what you get is a hotch potch of data which you then have to adjust manually as the flow of the data is lost upon importing.

Miscellaneous features

If a page layout software has features such as spell checker, wizards and templates, it is a bonus as they add to the software's functionality.



MS Publisher 2000 provides wizards and templates for ease of use

Spell checker: Spelling mistakes are common. After laying out the text, we normally run the spell checker to see if any typographical errors are present. The spell checker should be able to detect not only the spelling mistakes but also the duplicate

words. It can get pretty irritating if it keeps on ignoring proper nouns. The software should allow users to manually add names and not show it as an error the next time you run the spell check.

All the software that we tested had this feature and all were equally good.

Wizards: There are many software which provide wizards (step by step guidance) to create predefined documents. This makes the job easier and much faster than the manual process.

Except for Microsoft Publisher 2000, none of the software have wizards for generating documents. Publisher offers an extensive list of publications such as brochures, catalogues, greeting cards, etc that can be created very easily even by a novice with the help of wizards.

Templates: A template is a predefined design page which can be used as standard document as it contains a set of graphics and text in predefined layout. This feature is commonly use by newspapers and monthly publications where the template can consist of text, graphics, layout, placeholders, rulers, grid, etc. Software like Adobe's PageMaker now come bundled with sufficient templates to make things easier for the user.

PageMaker, Microsoft Publisher and Frame Maker provide an extensive list of templates which one can use for his work or rework on them to suit his need. InDesign and Quark haven't implemented this feature yet.

CONCLUSION

Even though PageMaker and QuarkXPress have been the all-time favourites, this time the equation changes a bit. Quark hasn't come out with a new version for quite a long time. Even though QuarkXPress 5 is

reportedly nearing completion, the retail version available in the market as of now is still 4.1.

Even with PageMaker, the new version fails to impress as the interface and features haven't changed much. Quark is feature rich, but lacks proper importing capabilities. Microsoft's Publisher 2000 offers a simple and easy-to-use solution for those not-so-design-inclined who want nothing but basic



Adobe InDesign 1.5: the most functional and versatile page layout software

design templates to make simple documents such as letterheads, business cards and memos.

What really toppled the top ranks was Adobe's InDesign, which, with its easy-to-use interface and a boatload of features overtook all the oldies. It has an extremely functional interface that rivals that of Photoshop. Adobe came out with this version a couple of months back, and a new 2.0 version has already been announced on Adobe's Web site. As of now, InDesign stands way ahead of all other page layout software in terms of user friendliness, features and usability. 

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